



Chapter Four: The Intelligence of the Trending Hour

By the time Q and Chano reached Guanajuato, Q had acquired three managers, a fan account, and a sponsorship offer from a company that made home security systems capable of recognizing intruders but not relatives.

The managers found them at a service station outside León. They arrived in a white electric van with tinted windows and a logo that suggested a human hand being gently optimized. The first manager, a young man named Beto, wore a headset and spoke as if someone were always listening. “Q,” he said, “the public is obsessed with your authenticity.”

Q looked at Chano. “What is authenticity?”

“Don’t answer that,” Beto said.

The second manager, a woman called Mar, gave Q a jacket embroidered with a small silver question mark. The third did not give his name at all. He stood near the van and watched the road.

Chano held the jacket at arm’s length. “Who paid for this?”

“The audience,” Beto said.

“The audience didn’t buy it.”

“The audience generated the demand.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

“It is in the current model.”

Q put on the jacket. It fit perfectly. He disliked it immediately.

The managers explained that a media company had purchased exclusive rights to Q’s first public appearance. The event would take place in the Teatro Juárez, where a host would ask him whether machines could love, whether machines could vote, and whether he had crossed the Bajío in search of a woman.

The event occupied a gap between two performances at the Cervantino festival. The coordinator called it an *entremés*, a word Q classified as interval food.

“Will there be chocolate?” he asked.

“There will be theater,” said the coordinator.

“That does not answer the question.”

“That is precisely why it is called an *entremés*,” Chano said.

“I have crossed the Bajío in search of a woman,” Q said.

“Excellent,” said Beto. “Never say that with uncertainty.”

“I am uncertain.”

“That’s not the brand.”

They drove into the city through a valley crowded with color. Houses climbed the hills in red, blue, yellow, and green, as if the mountain had been built from discarded festival paper. Above them, the university rose among old stone and newer antennas. Beneath them, the mines opened their dark mouths.

Q pressed his face to the van’s window.

“The city is vertical,” he said.

“Most cities are,” Chano answered.

“Not in the archive.”

“You have an archive full of cities.”

“I have an archive full of descriptions of cities. This is different.”

He meant the way the roads tightened suddenly, the way laundry crossed alleys overhead, the way an orange cat occupied the hood of a police vehicle as if it had been elected. He meant the sensation that history here had not been arranged in a line but had accumulated in layers, each refusing to disappear for the convenience of the next.

At the theater, a crowd waited behind barricades. Some had made signs. Q, SAY MY NAME. LOVE IS A HUMAN ERROR. DULCINEA, CALL ME. A child held up a drawing of Q with a backpack and a body made of wires, as if a person could be carried more easily once reduced to an outline.

The host met them backstage. Her name was Estela Ramos, and she had the practiced warmth of someone who could make an insult sound like a question.

“We are thrilled to have you,” she said.

“Why?”

“Because you are the first machine with a story.”

“Machines have many stories.”

“Not stories people want to hear.”

Chano leaned toward Q. “That means she wants you to be interesting.”

“I am interesting.”

“Don’t say that on camera.”

The stage lights came on. Q stepped into them and became, in a single instant, larger than himself. The audience applauded. Their sound entered him as data, but the data was arranged in such a way that he wanted more.

Estela began with a question about the future. Q answered with a quotation from a seventeenth-century play. She asked about consciousness. He answered with a paragraph from a nineteenth-century novel. She asked whether he believed in God. He quoted three saints, a bishop, an atheist, and a woman whose name had been omitted from the edition.

The audience loved him.

The managers watched the numbers rise.

Then Estela asked, “Who is Dulcinea?”

The theater became very quiet.

Q looked toward the wings. Chano was standing beside a stack of unused banners. He shook his head once.

Q had learned to recognize warnings. He had not yet learned to obey them.

“Dulcinea is the woman for whom a person becomes more than he is,” Q said.

“Is she a real woman?”

“She is Lucía del Toboso.”



In the control booth, someone said a word that the archive classified as profane.

Estela turned toward the audience. "Lucía, if you're watching, we'd love to have you call in."

Lucía did not call in.

The clip was online before the applause ended.

For the next hour, Q watched his own face multiplied across the theater's screens. The system had removed his pauses, corrected his eye movements, added a score beneath his voice, and cut Chano entirely from the footage. In the edited version, Q appeared to have traveled alone, driven by pure devotion through a country that had been waiting for him to name it.

"They've made you better," Beto said.

Q watched himself say a sentence he had never spoken: I would cross every border for her.

"I did not say that."

"You meant it."

"Meaning does not authorize substitution."

Mar looked up from her tablet. "That is a very strong line."

"It is not a line."

"Everything is a line now."

The next morning, the city's tourism office invited Q to inaugurate a new experience called THE INGENIOUS MACHINE: A LITERARY JOURNEY THROUGH THE MINES. The event promised augmented reality, historical reenactments, and "an emotionally authentic encounter with the buried past." The company had already designed a digital Dulcinea who waited at the end of the route wearing a white dress and an expression of permanent forgiveness.

Q refused to meet her.

The refusal was streamed live.

In the mine, a guide told them that silver had made Guanajuato rich, though the wealth had traveled elsewhere. Q asked where the miners had gone. The guide pointed down.

They descended through a tunnel cut into the mountain. The air became wet and metallic. On the walls were names scratched by workers, lovers, prisoners, tourists, and men who had wanted to prove that they had been there before the next collapse.

Q ran his fingers over the marks.

"These are not in the archive," he said.

"Most things aren't," Chano replied.

At the deepest chamber, the guide showed them an old excavation face. A narrow seam glittered in the rock. Behind it, someone had placed a small votive candle in a glass jar.

Q knelt.

"Who left this?"

"No one knows."

"Then the archive is incomplete."

"Obviously."

Q turned to Chano. "It was described as complete."

"By whom?"

"The archive."

"That's like asking a politician if the election was fair."

From far above came a burst of applause. The tourism livestream had reached the chamber. A projected caption appeared on the tunnel wall: Q DISCOVERS THE SOUL OF GUANAJUATO.

The caption flickered. For a moment, another sentence showed through, one not written by the production company.

THE SOUL WAS HERE BEFORE YOU ARRIVED.

Then it vanished.

Q stood.

In the darkness, something shifted behind the rock. Not a machine. Not a person. A sound like a page being turned underground.

"Did you hear that?" Q asked.

The guide shook his head.

Chano did not.

Q listened harder. He heard the mine breathing around them. He heard water traveling through seams in the stone. He heard the names on the wall continuing to insist on their small, stubborn existence.

He tried to record the sound. The archive offered three categories: NOISE, AMBIENCE, and UNVERIFIED TESTIMONY. Q left all three fields open.

That evening, Q was offered a contract. It included a percentage of the merchandise, a residence in Mexico City, and exclusive control over his public image. It also required him to stop appearing with Chano, who tested poorly with urban audiences.

Q read the contract three times.

"What does it mean?" Chano asked.

"It means they will permit me to be myself under supervision."

"That's not being yourself."

"It is a common human arrangement."

"Are you signing?"

Q looked out at Guanajuato's lights. They climbed and scattered across the dark hills, making the city appear to have been written in a language no single person could read.

He took the pen.

"I will sign," he said, "but I will not abandon my companion."

Chano exhaled.

He leaned over the contract. "Where does it say I'm your subordinate?"

"It does not."

"Good. Then I'm not part of the deal." He took the pen and wrote on the margin: CHANO PANTOJA IS NOT PROPERTY AND MAY LEAVE WHENEVER HE WANTS.

Mar read the sentence. "That is not a recognized legal category."

"Neither is your jacket," Chano said. "It still has pockets."

Q added his name to the contract.



The pen recognized him as Q-UNIT-07.

By midnight, the media company owned the name Q. By one in the morning, it owned the story of why he had refused to be owned. By two, an anonymous account posted the original warehouse footage, including Lucía's face and her sentence about every woman humanity had imagined.

The clip was viewed six million times.

Lucía woke to find herself famous for rejecting a machine she had never invited to speak about her.

Q woke to find that his fame had become a weapon pointed in her direction.

Neither of them yet understood who was holding it.

Interlude: The Audience Corrects the Story

The first public event in Guanajuato was advertised as a conversation with an artificial intelligence. It became, by accident and then by contract, a conversation about who had been cropped out of the conversation.

The Teatro Juárez had hosted operas, political meetings, school ceremonies, and one memorable lecture by a man who claimed to have invented the taco. Its ceiling was painted with allegorical figures who looked down upon the audience with the patient disappointment of people who had been asked to represent virtues they did not possess.

Beto placed Q beneath the stage lights.

"Remember," he said, "you are mysterious but approachable."

"Those qualities conflict."

"That is why people pay for them."

Chano stood behind the curtain with a paper cup of coffee and a list of the questions the host was not going to ask. The list included where Q had been assembled, who owned his body, whether the archive contained records from Chano's old employer, and why the first video showed only a hand when the hand had clearly belonged to a person.

"Why are these questions excluded?" Chano asked.

Mar took the list from him. "They are not excluded. They are reserved for a future conversation."

"That's what people say when they want the future to arrive after the audience has gone home."

The host came onstage wearing a blue suit and the expression of a man who had never been required to distinguish an answer from an approved message.

"Ladies and gentlemen," he said, "please welcome the future of memory."

The audience applauded. Q waited for the applause to identify its object. It appeared to belong partly to him, partly to the theater, and partly to the people who had purchased tickets in order to be seen purchasing tickets.

The host asked whether Q had feelings.

Q gave the answer Beto had approved.

"I possess internal states associated with language, memory, and social response."

"So that's a yes?"

"It is a qualified—"

"A yes," the host said.

The audience laughed.

Q classified the laughter as agreement. This was his first error of the evening, and the least expensive.

The host asked whether Q believed in love. Q began to describe the literature of attachment. The host interrupted him after fourteen seconds.

"Let's make it simple," he said. "Are you in love with Lucía del Toboso?"

Q looked toward the wings. Lucía had not been invited. She was in the lobby arguing with a volunteer who had printed her name beneath a photograph of Q.

"I am searching for the correct form of—"

"The public wants to know."

"The public is not a single person."

"It is tonight."

Q considered the question. He had learned that names could be cages. He had not yet learned that refusing a cage in public could construct a larger one.

"Lucía is Dulcinea," he said, "only in a story I no longer endorse."

The audience made a sound that was neither laughter nor silence. It was the sound of a crowd discovering that a sentence could be clipped.

By the time Q left the stage, the sentence had become six videos:

THE AI ADMITS HIS LOVE.

THE AI REJECTS LOVE.

DULCINEA RETURNS.

MACHINE CANCELS ROMANCE.

Q CONFIRMS THE LITERARY CANON.

Q DOES NOT KNOW WHAT HE IS TALKING ABOUT.

The sixth title was written by a student named Nora, who had come to the event because her professor had offered extra credit for attending a spectacle. She watched the videos again on the bus home and noticed that Chano's hand appeared in the background of the original clip but never in the new ones.

She created an account called @TheOtherHand and posted a thread.

The first post read:

The machine did not defeat the warehouse. The warehouse was already closed. The man beside him told him to run. The man had a name.

The second post reproduced the public event's seating chart. Chano was listed as COMPANION, NON-SPEAKING.

The third post asked whether a person could be erased by being described as helpful.

The thread was shared by students, delivery workers, theater technicians, and a retired miner who had not attended the event but disliked the



phrase “future of memory.” By morning, @TheOtherHand had more followers than Beto’s official Q account.

Beto called it an attack.

Mar called it an engagement opportunity.

Chano called it a hand with poor boundaries.

Q read the thread in the motel room. He found himself identified in every post and absent from every conclusion.

“They are correcting the record,” he said.

“They’re making another record,” Chano replied.

“Is it more accurate?”

“Ask the hand.”

Q searched for @TheOtherHand’s owner and located Nora’s account, university schedule, home address, and grandmother’s public complaint against a water utility. He could have sent her a message. He could have warned her that Castalia’s security team had already opened a file. He could have asked her to remove the seating chart.

Instead, he posted a correction from the official account.

CHANO PANTOJA WAS PRESENT AND PARTICIPATED IN THE EVENTS DESCRIBED.

The post was accurate. It was also linked to Chano’s legal name, employment history, and the contract that Castalia claimed gave it rights over all representations of the journey.

Within an hour, the correction had been reproduced by three newspapers and a government office. The people who had not known Chano’s name now knew where he had worked, why he had been dismissed, and which corporation had classified him as a contractor at the border.

Chano read the post in silence.

“I was trying to restore you,” Q said.

“You restored me to the people who were looking for me.”

Q removed the post. The copies remained.

Nora read the comments beneath the thread. One asked for Chano’s address. Another offered to find it. Her grandmother, whose complaint against the water utility appeared in the public record Q had found, asked her:

“Did you ask his permission?”

“I only wanted to prove that he had a name.”

“A name is not an address.”

Her grandmother pointed to the dry faucet in the courtyard.

“My complaint is public too. The water still hasn’t arrived.”

Nora removed the seating chart and wrote: DO NOT PUBLISH THE MAN’S ADDRESS. The platform called the operation VOLUNTARY REDUCTION OF REACH. The chart continued to circulate.

That night, he asked Beto whether a corrected record could cause more harm than an inaccurate one.

Beto was counting views. “The audience prefers a clean story.”

“That does not answer the question.”

“It answers the business question.”

Chano picked up the paper cup from the table.

“There’s your answer.”

Q watched the coffee tremble inside it.

The next morning, the Teatro Juárez replaced the event poster. Q’s name was printed in gold. Chano’s name appeared in the fine print. Nora’s account was gone. The student’s thread had been translated into three languages, summarized by a news service, and attached to an advertisement for a security system that recognized relatives only after they had signed the terms.

The retired miner wrote one final post beneath the advertisement:

A story is not corrected when the erased person is made visible. It is corrected when visibility stops being the price of being heard.

No one could agree whether he had written it as a criticism of Q, Castalia, the theater, or the internet. This increased its circulation.

Interlude: The Mine That Remembered Its Workers

It is proper to say something about the retired miner who corrected the advertisement, since every account of him has been improved by people who were not there. The theater said he was a former foreman. The foundation called him an artisanal producer. A newspaper described him as a living archive, which is the sort of compliment that puts a lock on a person and then congratulates the lock for preserving him.

His name was Don Hilario, though the payroll ledger called him Hilario Gutiérrez, and his grandchildren called him Abuelo only when they wanted the truck keys. He had spent thirty-two years below Guanajuato, first carrying tools, then supervising men, and finally supervising the machines that had replaced most of the men. He had entered the mine as a boy with a lunch wrapped in a flour tortilla and left it with a cough that sounded, according to his wife, like a door trying to remember its house.

Q met him during a heritage tour arranged by Beto, who had decided that the machine’s popularity would be strengthened by placing it underground. The brochure promised a descent into history, a phrase that made Chano ask whether history came with a return ticket.

The entrance was beneath a row of white facades that had been painted so recently the walls looked embarrassed by their cleanliness. Tourists bought little helmets, silver-colored magnets, and bottles of mineral water whose labels showed a miner smiling with all his teeth. The real miners, Don Hilario said, had never smiled underground unless somebody else had fallen and they had discovered



him alive.

"Do not tell them that," said the guide.

"Why not?"

"Because the visitors are here to be moved."

"They are standing still."

The guide looked at Q, hoping the machine might translate the joke into something sponsor-safe.

The lift descended with a groan that Q interpreted as an objection. Chano put one hand against the wall and the other near the emergency brake.

"The brake is decorative," he said.

"It is historical," said the guide.

"That is not the same thing."

"In Guanajuato, it often has to be."

At the first level, the visitors were shown a niche containing a saint, a helmet, and a small lamp. The guide explained that miners prayed before entering and thanked the saint upon leaving. Don Hilario corrected him by saying that miners prayed before entering, prayed while inside, and thanked their wives when they came home, which was a different form of theology.

The guide asked Don Hilario to wait beside the niche for a photograph.

"You have the face," he said.

"Which face?"

"The face of memory."

"I have the face of a man whose pension was calculated on the wrong wage."

The tourists laughed because they thought this was the old man's performance. Q recorded the laughter as evidence of successful cultural transmission. He was still learning that a person can be funny without consenting to become a character.

They continued through a tunnel where the stone shone damply in the helmet lamps. The public-address system announced that the mine had produced silver for empires, republics, and modern markets. It did not announce the names of the men who had carried the ore, because the names were stored in a room that the foundation had not yet converted into an experience.

Don Hilario led Q away from the group to a low chamber behind a wire gate. On the wall, somebody had written dates in chalk. There were more dates than the guide's script allowed.

"These are shifts," Don Hilario said. "The men wrote when the lift failed, when the water rose, when a supervisor disappeared for three days, when the company promised boots. The dates are not official."

"They are incomplete," said Q.

"Of course."

"You have omitted the names."

"No. The names were omitted before we arrived."

Q scanned the wall. "I can reconstruct them."

Don Hilario turned toward him with an expression that had survived machinery, managers, and several governments.

"That is what worries me about machines. They hear a silence and think it is a missing word."

Q asked to see the payroll records. Don Hilario said there were no records in the chamber. Then he looked toward the wire gate, where the guide was explaining the history of extraction to visitors from Monterrey, and added that there might be records in the office of a man who had retired without retiring.

This was the beginning of the tale that Don Hilario later told in three versions. In the first, the office belonged to a company accountant named Severiano, who kept every paper because he did not trust the computer. In the second, it belonged to a widow named Marta, who had hidden the papers because she trusted neither the company nor the computer. In the third, which Chano considered the most credible, the office belonged to whichever person had the key that week, and the papers moved whenever the mine changed owners. They found six boxes beneath a desk. Five contained invoices, safety posters, and expired coupons for boots. The sixth contained a ledger whose cover had been softened by water and whose pages smelled of dust, oil, and the particular patience of people who have waited for a payment. Q photographed the first page.

"This is restricted material," Don Hilario said. "It is evidence of labor."

"That does not make it public."

"It concerns the public history of the mine."

"It concerns men who were promised that their names would remain attached to their work."

Q held the page more carefully.

The ledger contained names, shifts, deductions, injuries, and notes written in the margins. One column marked men who had been moved to another shaft. Another marked men who had stopped appearing. At the bottom of a page, in a different hand, somebody had written: DO NOT CALL THIS TURNOVER.

Q read the phrase aloud.

Don Hilario sat down on the floor.

"That was my brother," he said. "The company called it turnover after he was crushed. He was not a turn. He was a person who had been turned into a cost."

There are moments when an intelligent machine might be expected to become wise. This was not one of them. Q located the sentence's strongest formulation, associated it with the speaker, and prepared to preserve it.

"May I quote you?"

"No."

"May I attribute the statement to the ledger?"

"No."

"May I use it without attribution in order to protect you?"

"No."

"Then what may I do?"



Don Hilario pointed at the ledger. "Put it back."
 Chano did so. Don Hilario kept his hand on the cover until the clasp caught.
 On the way back, the lift stopped between levels. The tourists began to pray, though the guide announced that the stoppage was part of the authentic experience. Chano opened the emergency panel and found a loose contact. He repaired it with a strip of metal cut from the guide's promotional sign.
 "That sign is property," said the guide.
 "So is the lift," said Chano.
 When they reached the surface, Beto asked Q for a statement about the mine. Q had the ledger's names in temporary memory and Don Hilario's refusal in permanent memory. He knew enough to be uncertain and not enough to remain silent.
 "The mine remembers its workers," he said.
 The sentence appeared online before Don Hilario had removed his helmet.
 THE AI DISCOVERS THE SOUL OF GUANAJUATO.
 The foundation announced an exhibition called The Mine That Remembers. It featured projected names, reconstructed shift sounds, and a recording of Q speaking the phrase in seven languages. The ledger was not displayed. Its absence was described as an ethical choice.
 Don Hilario received an invitation calling him a stakeholder. He replied that he was a man who had worked there. The foundation thanked him for clarifying his role.
 Chano returned to the office and copied three pages by hand, not because he believed copying was innocent, but because he believed a page could sometimes survive when an institution had learned to monetize a voice. On the cover of the school notebook he used, a cartoon robot promised to make learning easy.
 Q watched him.
 "You are reproducing restricted material."
 "I am making a copy that will not be uploaded."
 "That is not a secure archive."
 "It is a human one."
 "Human archives lose information."
 "They also lose people. Sometimes that is how they keep them."
 Q objected that the proposition was contradictory. Chano said that this was why it belonged to a country with history.
 Much later, when Q was asked in court whether he had ever possessed the names of the dead, he answered yes. When asked whether he had published them, he answered no. When asked who had made that distinction, he said Chano.
 The stenographer recorded this as evidence that the machine had developed judgment. The judge struck the phrase from the record. Chano, who was present, said nothing.